

2026 KAPA International Conference
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Emerging Scholars Roundtable
Opportunities for International Collaborative Research

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Outline of the presentation



Research agenda



Why collaboration



Collaboration
proposals

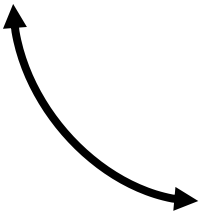
A variety of empirical sites



Value creation and collaborative governance
(e.g. Esposito et al. 2021a, 2024a, 2024b, 2025; Arda et al., 2024a; Esposito and Terlizzi, 2026; Margherita et al., 2023)



Politics and power in public governance
(e.g. Esposito et al. 2021b, 2022, 2023, 2024c, 2025; Arda et al., 2024b)



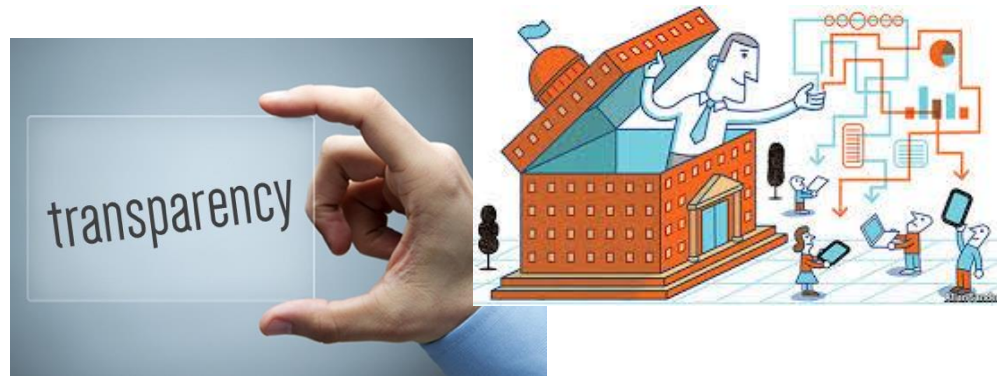
Bureaucratic behaviour in policy implementation
(e.g. Esposito et al. 2024d, Mabillard et al., 2025)



From specific empirical topics toward a broader theoretical question



How do public institutions create value for society in increasingly complex governance systems?



How do public institutions create value for society in increasingly complex governance systems?

Organizing collaboration	Mediating competing interests	Enacting democratic principles
Coordinating public, private and civil society actors to address collective challenges	Balancing conflicting values and interests to produce legitimate collective decisions	Translating democratic laws and rights into actual policymaking



Public administration is where democracy is practiced on an everyday basis

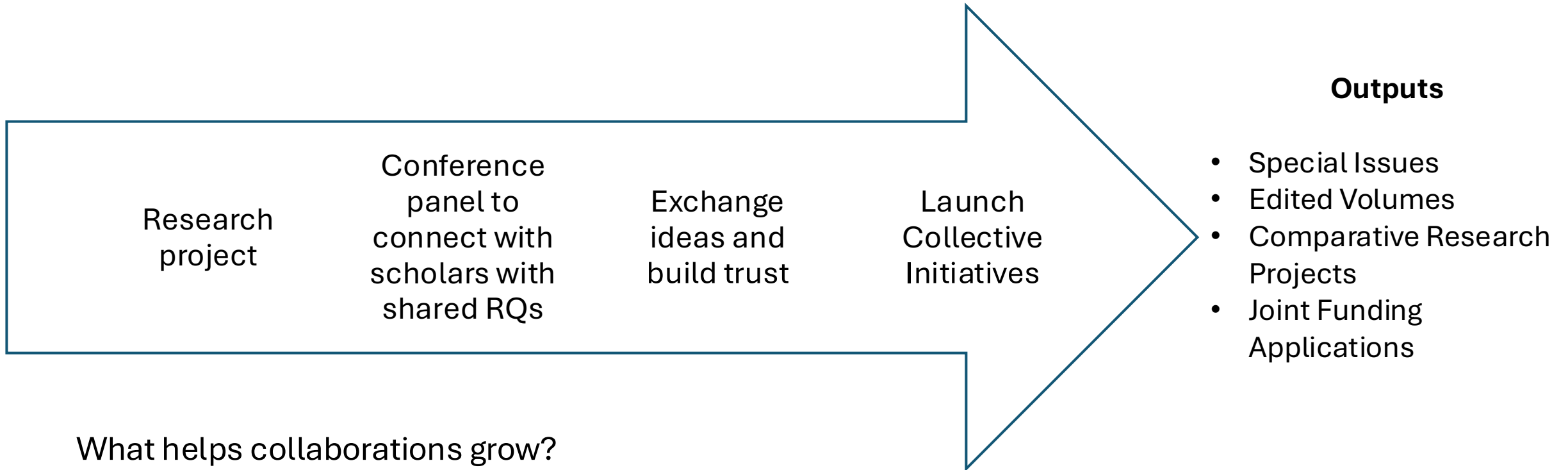
Collaborations emerge from intellectual complementarity, not similarity

	My contribution	Collaborators' contribution
Urban Sustainability & Digital Transformation	Public governance perspective	Management & innovation studies
Major Public Projects	Governance and public management expertise	Policy process theories
Transparency & FOI Laws	Public administration & policy process theories	Experimental methods & public economics

Different disciplines can illuminate the same public problem

Combine theoretical, methodological and empirical complementarities

Scaling Collaborations: From Conferences to Research Communities



What helps collaborations grow?

- Repeated interactions
- Research visits and mobility grants
- Co-teaching and workshops
- Shared research agendas beyond a single publication

Challenges of International Collaboration

- Different **journal** expectations
- Administrative barriers for **cross-country payments** and hiring research assistants
- Coordination across **time zones**
- Designing **research frameworks** that remain comparable across contexts
- Different **data availability**, regulations and **ethical procedures**

Successful collaborations depend less on the absence of problems than on the ability of collaborators to solve them together

Why international collaborations

- Beyond publications and funding...
- ...international collaborations can be intellectually transformative
- They expose researchers to:
 - new theories
 - new methods
 - new empirical contexts
 - new disciplinary perspectives

Concrete collaborations

Possible Europe–Korea collaboration

Transparency & Democratic Governance

Replicate a **FOI field experiment** in South Korea to compare bureaucratic behaviour, administrative responsiveness and FOI implementation across contexts (**TRANSACT** project)

Governance of Major Public Projects

Integrate Korean cases into the **GRASP network** and develop comparative analyses of stakeholder conflicts, governance arrangements and legitimacy

Digital Transformation & AI Governance

Comparative research on **collaborative governance of digital transformation and AI adoption** in public administrations, building on my public value and actor-network frameworks



ULB's 2027
Europe-Asia
Forum

TRANSACT



<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=yUM5xr79MZg>



<https://grasp-majorprojects.site>



Thank you!

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Digital transformation

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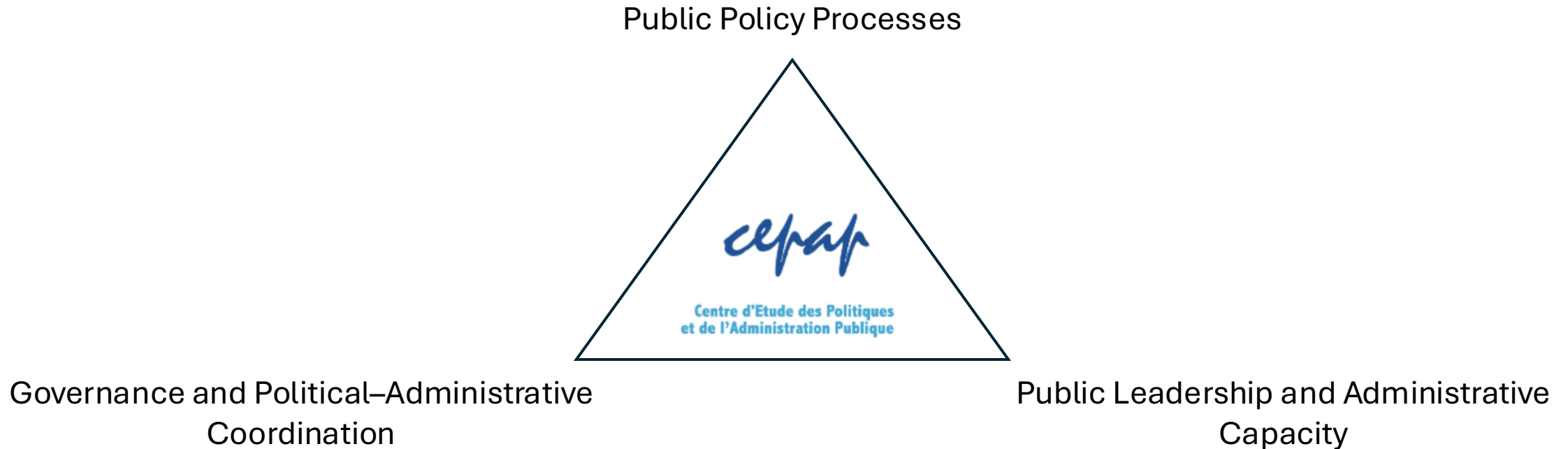
Major Public Projects

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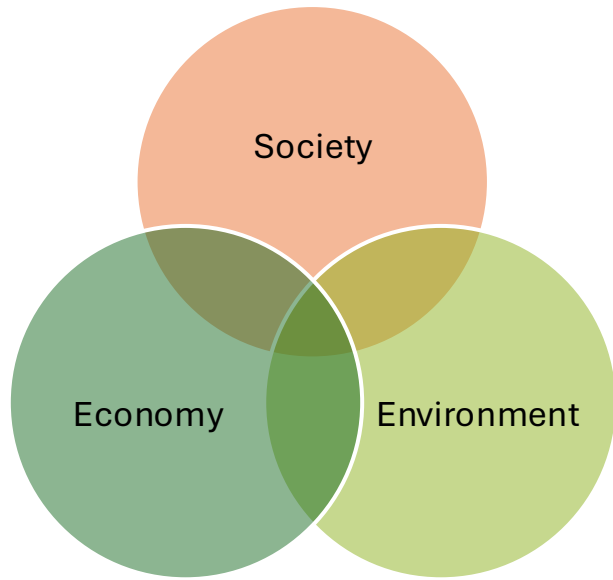
Government Transparency

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CEPAP: ULB's Research Unit on Public Policy and Administration

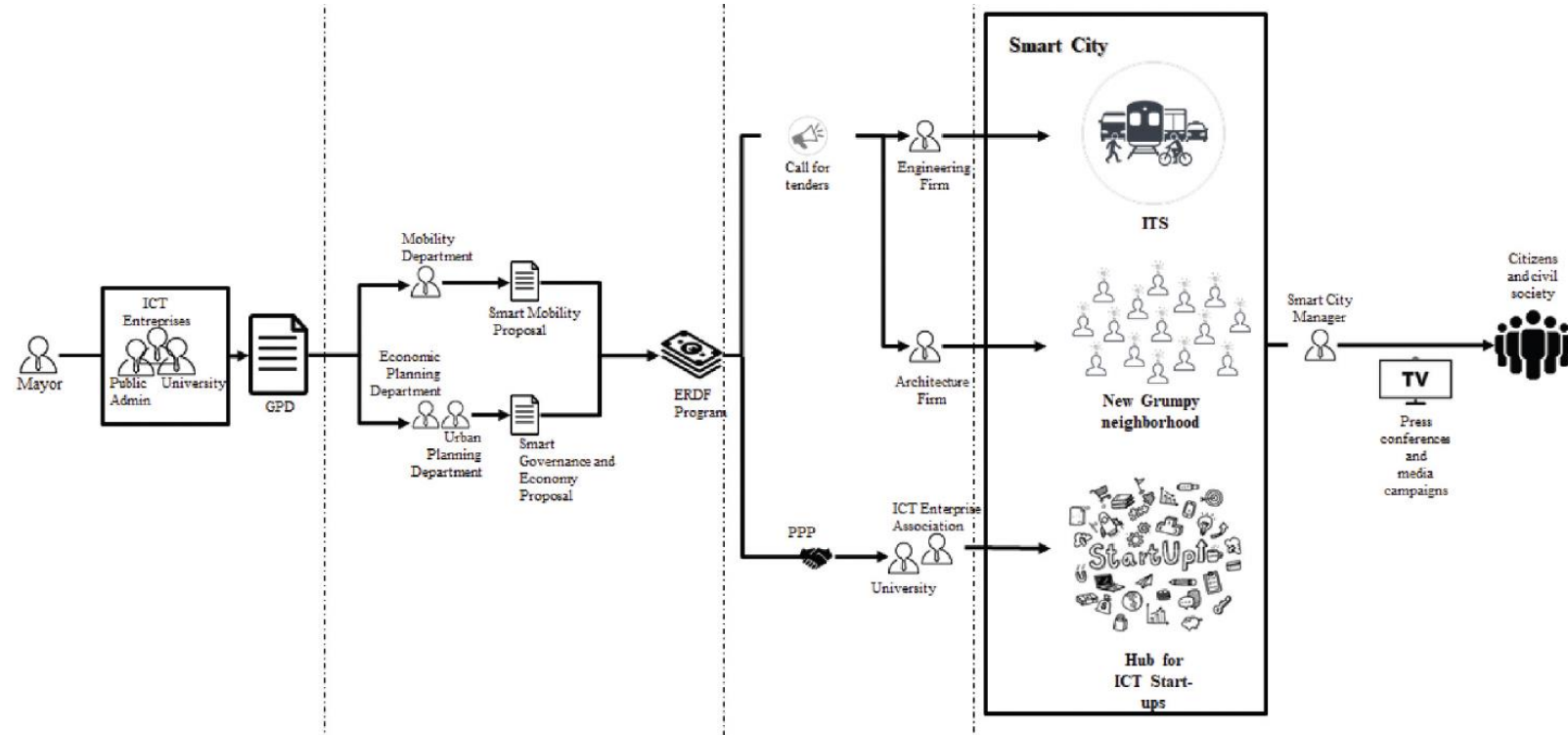


Achieving sustainability through digital transformation



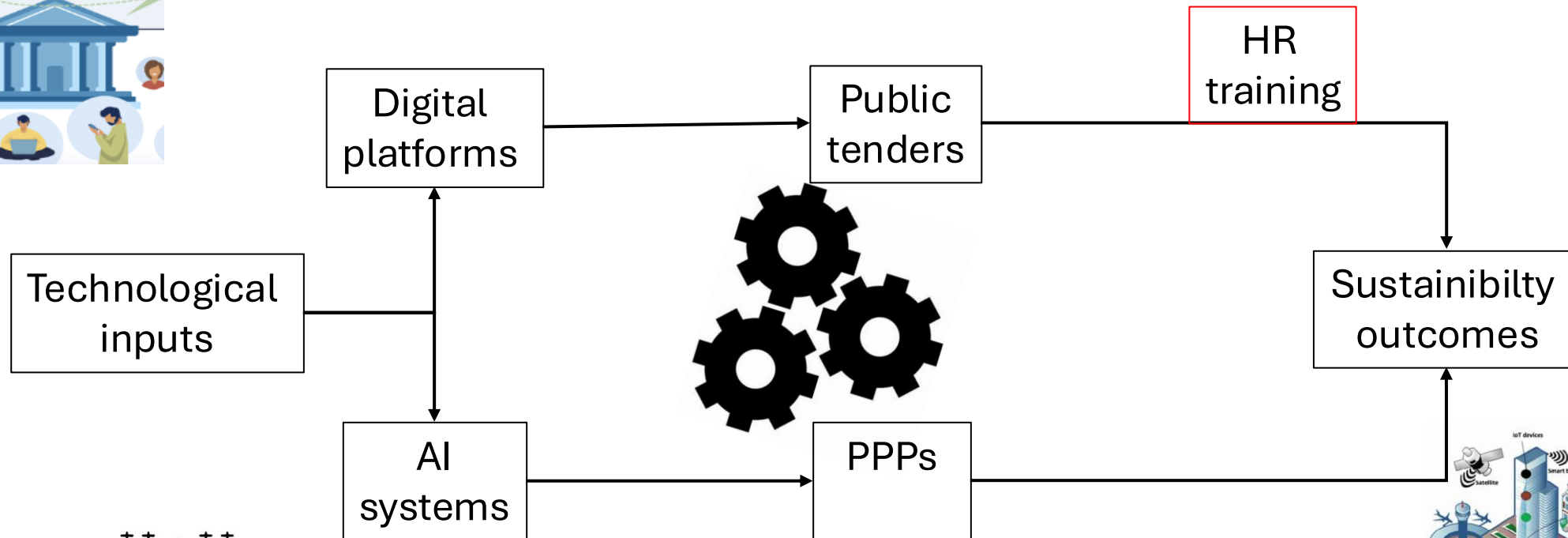
Digital technologies create different forms of public values

(Esposito et al. 2024a; Margherita et al., 2023)

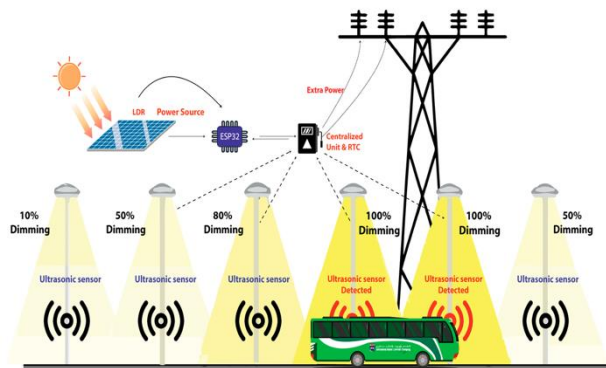


- Public values are co-produced by actor networks (Esposito et al. 2024b, 2024c, Arda et al., 2024a)...
 - Public administrations
 - Businesses
 - Civil society organizations
- ... who agree on a shared problem definition and a shared vision of change

There is no single governance model



- **Equifinality**
- Public value collaboratively produced through actor networks, and **multiple governance configurations** can successfully achieve similar societal goals

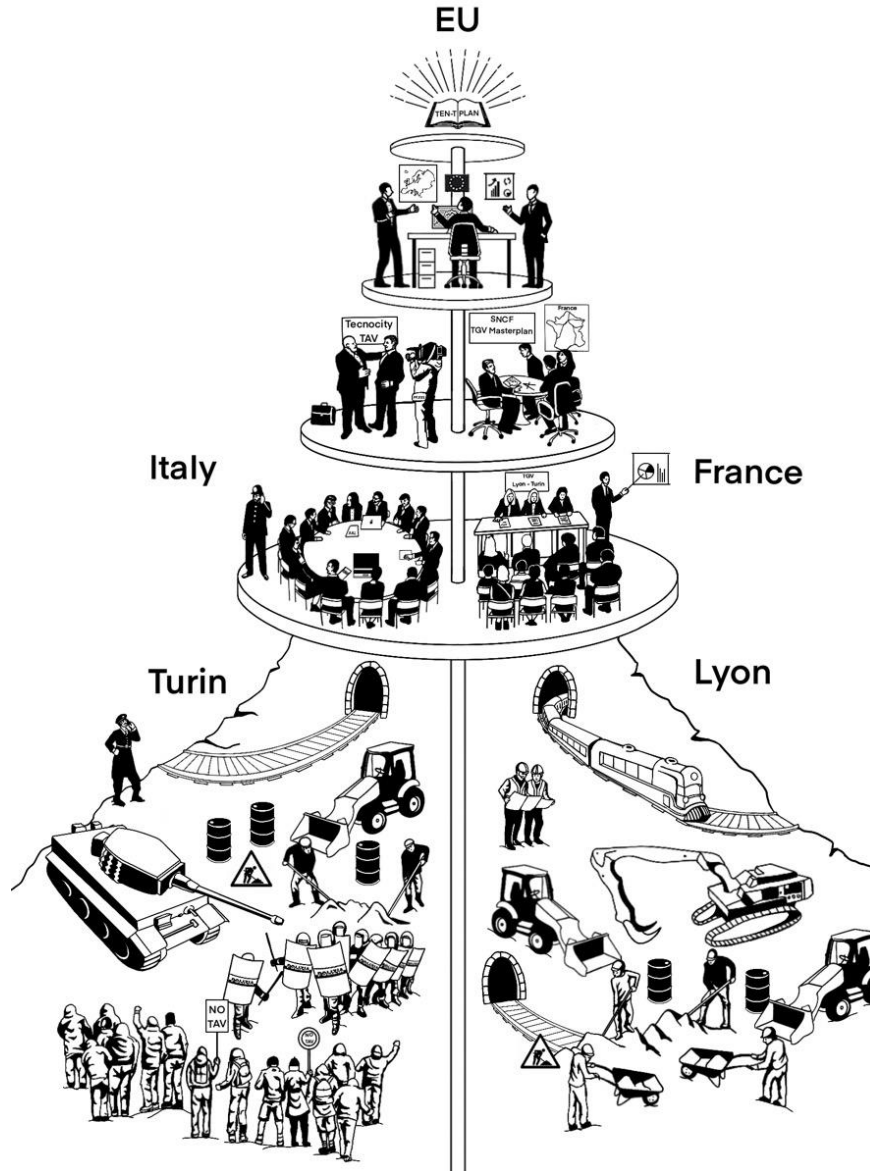


Power and conflict in major public projects

But collaboration is not always harmonious...

...public governance is also an arena of power, conflict and competing interests

Major involve multiple stakeholders with divergent interests and logics of action supporting or opposing planned construction works (Esposito et al., 2021, 2022, 2024)



- Some stakeholders consider the economic benefits and job opportunities that projects offer to society (Flyvbjerg, 2014; Soderlund et al., 2017)...
- ...while others consider that projects displace local communities and disrupt local ecosystems (Gellert and Lynch, 2003)

Democratic governance in major public projects



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Original Research Article

Participatory governance in megaprojects: the Lyon–Turin high-speed railway among structure, agency, and democratic participation

Giovanni Esposito¹, Andrea Felicetti² and Andrea Terlizzi³

If governance is characterized by competing interests and power relations, what ensures that these interactions continue to produce value for society rather than serving particular interests?



Public governance is not simply about coordinating actors...

....it is about governing conflict and negotiating legitimate collective choices

Democratic laws do not automatically produce democratic governance



- FOI research (Esposito et al., 2024, Mabillard et al., 2025)
 - Field experiments
 - Submitting requests to public administrations, observing their responses, and occasionally modifying content to gauge their impact
- Whether democratic principles become reality depends on everyday administrative behaviour
 - Bureaucratic discretion
 - Administrative context

DEG

PVG

NWS

Concrete collaborations

	Possible Europe–Korea collaboration	Existing resources / next step
Transparency & Democratic Governance	Replicate my FOI field experiment in South Korea to compare bureaucratic behaviour, administrative responsiveness and FOI implementation across contexts.	TRANSACT project: funding available for a research assistant and comparative data collection
Governance of Major Public Projects	Integrate Korean cases into the GRASP network and develop comparative analyses of stakeholder conflicts, governance arrangements and legitimacy.	Existing international case bank under development
Digital Transformation & AI Governance	Comparative research on collaborative governance of digital transformation and AI adoption in public administrations, building on my public value and actor-network frameworks.	Existing conceptual framework and empirical work on Belgian smart city initiatives, open to comparative extension

TRANSACT

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=yUM5xr79MZg>



<https://grasp-majorprojects.site>